WOLFE

BY DORIAN WOLFE

GUIDE + 70 CARDS · USA · CANADA · UK

CONVERSATION STARTERS AFTER 35

The psychology of why talking feels hard, and what he can ask her, what she can ask him, and what anyone can ask.

DORIAN WOLFE · AI-GENERATED CHARACTER

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Dorian Wolfe is an AI-generated character, not a real person, and has no personal life story. This is general communication advice for adults. It is not therapy, medical, legal or financial advice, and no result is guaranteed. Always respect other people's boundaries and consent.

START HERE

WHY TALKING FEELS HARDER NOW

You may be 35, 45 or 55. You may be newly divorced, widowed, coming out of a long relationship, or single for years. Either way, you know how to hold a conversation at work, with friends, with family. Yet a first message or a first date can make your mind go blank.

That is common. It is not a flaw. This guide explains **why** it happens, shows what research does and does not say, and gives you **questions to ask**, for both sides: what he can ask her, what she can ask him, and what anyone can ask.

What it is	A guide to conversation after 35: psychology, plain-English rules, 70+ question cards, topic scripts and worksheets.
Who it is for	Men and women, in the USA, Canada and the UK, dating again or for the first time in years.
What it is not	A set of tricks. Nothing here is built to manipulate anyone, and nothing promises a date or a partner.

A NOTE ON EVIDENCE

I found almost no research on first conversations among people over 35. Most studies of conversation used students or strangers in labs. So this guide marks each idea as research (with its limits), common advice, or my own reasoning. Dorian Wolfe is an AI-generated character with no personal story, so none of this is "what happened to me".

THE MIND

EIGHT THINGS GOING ON IN YOUR HEAD

Usual reasons conversation feels hard after 35. They come from counselling-style advice and common sense, not from studies of this age group, so treat them as likely, not proven.

1. "I am rusty"	It has been years, and the way people meet has changed. **Do:** expect to be clumsy at first, and say once: "I have not done this in a while."
2. "I will look foolish"	Fear of saying the wrong thing makes you say nothing. **Do:** a short, simple question is better than a clever one.
3. "What if I get hurt again?"	After a divorce or loss, it is normal to be guarded. **Do:** go at a pace you choose, and say so.
4. Comparing with the ex or late spouse	It is easy to hold a new person up against someone you knew for years. **Do:** notice the comparison, then ask about the person in front of you.
5. "I do not have time"	Work, children, parents to care for. **Do:** suggest simple plans (a coffee, a walk).
6. "I am too old, or too (anything)"	Age and body worries make people hide. **Do:** be honest about your age and aim for warm, not impressive.
7. Grief and guilt	Guilt or rawness can surface mid-conversation. **Do:** it is fine to say "I lost my husband/wife, and some days are harder." There is no right timetable.
8. "I do not know the rules any more"	Apps, texting norms, who messages first. **Do:** there is no single rule. Be clear and kind.

WHAT RESEARCH SAYS

THREE FINDINGS, AND THEIR LIMITS

The few findings with support. All come from students, strangers or general adults, not daters over 35. Use them as ideas, not rules.

Follow-up questions	Huang and colleagues (2017) found people who asked more questions, especially **follow-ups**, were better liked, and in a speed-dating sample were more likely to get a "yes" for a second date. **Limit:** other researchers have debated the method, and asking is not listening.
The liking gap	Boothby and colleagues (2018) found people tend to **underestimate** how much the other person liked them after a conversation. **Limit:** strangers and students. Safe reading: they may have enjoyed it more than you think.
Matching depth	Aron and colleagues (1997): pairs who took turns answering gradually more personal questions felt closer than pairs given small talk. **Limit:** a lab task. No list of questions makes people fall in love.

WHAT US SURVEY DATA ADDS

A Pew survey of US online daters (2023, all ages) found men were much more likely to feel they got too few messages, and women more likely to feel they got too many or to report unwanted contact. The same app can feel like silence to one person and noise to another.

THE RULES

FIVE RULES FOR CONVERSATION AFTER 35

1. One question, one share	Ask something, then share a little yourself. Questions without sharing feel like an interview. Sharing without questions feels like a speech.
2. Follow up before you switch	When they answer, ask one more thing about that answer before you change topic. "Tell me more", "What did you like about it?"
3. Match the depth	If they answer lightly, stay light. If they open up, you may go a step deeper. Do not skip ahead.
4. Be clear about your pace	Say in plain words what pace you like. "I would like to go slowly" is a complete sentence.
5. Be honest about the basics	Age, kids, divorce, work. Short and kind. You do not have to share every detail on day one.

THE "I AM NERVOUS" LINE

It is allowed to say, "I will be honest, I am a bit nervous. It has been a while." Most people relax when you do.

WHO GOES FIRST, AND WHAT TO ASK

"Should the man ask, or the woman?" There is **no strong evidence that one gender should always go first.** Apps differ. What matters is that the first message is easy to answer.

WHY THE QUESTIONS DIFFER (INFERENCE, NOT PROVEN)

- Many men find it hard to get **any** replies, so they need questions that are warm, low-pressure and easy to answer.
- Many women get **too many** messages, some unwanted, so they need questions that check **intentions, pace and comfort** quickly.
- Anyone can use any card in this guide.

For him to ask her	Curious, light, easy to answer, with a clear offer to go at her pace.
For her to ask him	What he wants, how he handles disagreement, what his life looks like, so she can decide how she feels.
For anyone	Light questions, and honest ones for nerves.

FOR HIM TO ASK HER

HIM → HER · EASY

What has been the best part of your week so far?

1

HIM → HER · EASY

What do you do when you have a free Saturday?

2

HIM → HER · EASY

What is something small you have been enjoying lately?

3

HIM → HER · EASY

What made you choose this place (or this app)?

4

HIM → HER · EASY

What is your favourite thing to eat when nobody is watching?

5

HIM → HER · EASY

What are you looking forward to this month?

6

HIM → HER · EASY

Is there a show, book or podcast you keep telling people about?

7

HIM → HER · EASY

What does a really good day off look like for you?

8

FOR HIM TO ASK HER

HIM → HER · WARM

What is something you are proud of that does not show on a profile?

9

HIM → HER · WARM

What do you like most about where you live?

10

HIM → HER · WARM

Who is the person you call when you have good news?

11

HIM → HER · WARM

What did you do for fun as a kid that you still miss?

12

HIM → HER · WARM

What kind of trip would you take if time and money were no problem?

13

HIM → HER · WARM

What has changed for you in the last few years that you are glad about?

14

HIM → HER · WARM

What does a good friend do for you?

15

HIM → HER · WARM

What would you like more of in your life right now?

16

FOR HIM TO ASK HER

HIM → HER · STEADY

What would be a good pace for you? I am happy to go slowly.

17

HIM → HER · STEADY

Is there anything that would help you feel comfortable on a first date?

18

HIM → HER · STEADY

What are you hoping to find, if you do not mind me asking?

19

HIM → HER · STEADY

Is there anything I should know about your schedule, so I can plan around it?

20

HIM → HER · STEADY

Is there a place or an activity you would rather do than a restaurant?

21

HIM → HER · STEADY

If I say something that does not land well, will you tell me?

22

HIM → HER · STEADY

How do you like to stay in touch while we get to know each other: texts, calls, something else?

23

HIM → HER · STEADY

Is there something you would like me to ask you about?

24

FOR HER TO ASK HIM

HER → HIM · EASY

What does a normal week look like for you?

25

HER → HIM · EASY

What do you do for fun when you are not working?

26

HER → HIM · EASY

What is the best thing you have eaten recently?

27

HER → HIM · EASY

What made you decide to try meeting people again?

28

HER → HIM · EASY

What is something you could talk about for an hour?

29

HER → HIM · EASY

What is the last thing that made you laugh properly?

30

HER → HIM · EASY

Is there a place near here that you love?

31

HER → HIM · EASY

What are you looking forward to this month?

32

FOR HER TO ASK HIM

HER → HIM · INTENTIONS

What are you hoping to find? A relationship, company, something still undecided?

33

HER → HIM · INTENTIONS

What does a good relationship look like to you, day to day?

34

HER → HIM · INTENTIONS

How long has it been since your last relationship, and how are you feeling about dating now?

35

HER → HIM · INTENTIONS

What did you learn from your last relationship that you would do differently?

36

HER → HIM · INTENTIONS

How do you like to deal with it when you disagree with someone?

37

HER → HIM · INTENTIONS

What would you need from a partner that you could not do without?

38

HER → HIM · INTENTIONS

How do you feel about moving fast, moving slowly, or somewhere in between?

39

HER → HIM · INTENTIONS

Is there anything you want me to know early, so there are no surprises later?

40

HER → HIM · LIFE

Do you have children or other people you take care of? How does that shape your week?

41

HER → HIM · LIFE

How are things between you and your ex now, in a sentence?

42

HER → HIM · LIFE

What does your work take out of you, and what does it give you?

43

HER → HIM · LIFE

How do you look after your health and your free time?

44

HER → HIM · LIFE

Who are the people in your life that I would hear about?

45

HER → HIM · LIFE

What are you building at the moment: a home, a career, a hobby?

46

HER → HIM · LIFE

What would a good weekend with someone you care about look like?

47

HER → HIM · LIFE

Is there anything that would make you feel safe and comfortable meeting me?

48

ANYONE · LIGHT

What is the best thing that happened to you this week?

49

ANYONE · LIGHT

If you could be anywhere for a long weekend, where would it be?

50

ANYONE · LIGHT

What is a skill you wish you had picked up years ago?

51

ANYONE · LIGHT

What is the one app on your phone you could not live without?

52

ANYONE · LIGHT

What is your go-to meal when you cannot be bothered?

53

ANYONE · LIGHT

What was the last concert, match or event you really enjoyed?

54

ANYONE · LIGHT

What is your favourite season, and what do you do in it?

55

ANYONE · LIGHT

What is a small thing that always puts you in a good mood?

56

ANYONE · HONEST

I have not done this in years, so I might be a bit rusty. How about you?

57

ANYONE · HONEST

What is the best part about being this age? I would like to hear yours.

58

ANYONE · HONEST

What do you know about yourself now that you wish you had known at 25?

59

ANYONE · HONEST

What is something you have let go of that felt heavy for a long time?

60

ANYONE · HONEST

What do you need to feel at ease with someone new?

61

ANYONE · HONEST

What would a good first few dates look like, for you?

62

ANYONE · HONEST

What kind of people make you feel at home?

63

ANYONE · HONEST

What is something you are working on in yourself right now?

64

GOOD AND WORRYING ANSWERS

WHAT THE ANSWERS TELL YOU

Questions are only half of it. Listen to the answers, and to how the other person treats your answers. This is **common-sense guidance**, not a test. One answer never decides anything.

ANSWERS THAT FEEL GOOD

- They answer, then ask you something back.
- They are specific. They tell a small story, not a slogan.
- They respect "no", "not yet" or "I would like to go slower".
- They are honest when the answer is awkward ("we are still sorting out the divorce").
- You feel calmer, not more anxious, after the chat.

ANSWERS TO SLOW DOWN FOR

- They speak badly about every ex and blame everyone else.
- They push for more contact or more intimacy than you want.
- They get annoyed when you say "not yet".
- Their story changes between messages.
- They ask you for money, or for photos or details you are not ready to share. (See the scam red-flag checklist.)

TRUST YOURSELF

If something feels wrong, you do not need to explain. You can end the chat politely, or stop replying if you feel unsafe.

SENSITIVE TOPICS

HARD TOPICS, SAID SIMPLY

No professional body sets rules on what to say when. This is common counselling-style guidance, so adapt it. Say a **short, honest line** early. Save the long story for when you trust each other.

Your ex	"I was married for twelve years. It ended two years ago, and I am in a good place now." Then move on. Avoid long stories or running them down.
Your late spouse	"I am widowed. I lost my wife / husband three years ago. I will mention them sometimes, and that is part of my life." It is fine to say this early.
Children	Mention them early, because they affect your time. Wait to introduce them to someone new until things feel steady.
Age	Be honest. "I am 47." You do not have to apologise.
Work and money	Keep it light at first. Share more as trust builds. Never lend money to someone you have just met.
Health	Share what affects plans when it becomes relevant. You do not owe anyone your medical history on date one.
What you want	"I am looking for something real, and I do not mind if it takes time." Ask the same, plainly.
Exclusivity, pace	Do not guess. "I am enjoying this. Are you seeing other people?" And: "I would like to go slowly." Consent matters at every step.

MESSAGES

FIRST MESSAGES AND REPLIES

A first message needs one thing: it must be easy to answer. Use something from their profile, ask one question, and keep it short.

EXAMPLE: HIM TO HER

HIM

Hi Priya, I noticed your photo with the lake. Do you get out there much?

HER

Most weekends in summer. Do you hike?

HIM

Slowly, and with snacks. What is your favourite trail?

EXAMPLE: HER TO HIM

HER

Hi Tom, you mention you cook. What is the dish you are proudest of?

HIM

A slow-cooked lamb. It takes all day. What do you cook?

HER

Soups, mostly. I like things that look after themselves.

FOR EXAMPLES ONLY

Made-up names and messages that show a pattern. Use your own words. To end a chat politely: "Thank you for chatting. I do not think we are the right match, but I wish you well."

THE FIRST DATE

A SIMPLE FLOW FOR THE FIRST HOUR

0-5 minutes	Say hello, ask how the journey was, and say one honest line: "I am a bit nervous."
5-20 minutes	Easy questions. Place, food, weekend. Follow up on one thing they say.
20-45 minutes	Warm questions. Work, family, interests. Share a little in return.
45-60 minutes	Check the pace. "I have enjoyed this. Would you like to do something again?" A clear yes, a no, or a maybe are all fine.

IF CONVERSATION STALLS

- Return to something they said earlier: "You mentioned the lake..."
- Ask a light card: "What are you looking forward to this month?"
- Say what you notice: "This place is lovely, have you been here before?"
- Pause. A short silence is not a failure.

THE LIKING GAP AGAIN

After the date, you may think it went worse than it did. Wait a day before you decide.

AVOID

QUESTIONS TO LEAVE OUT

- ✕ "Why are you still single?"
- ✕ "How much do you earn?" or "Do you own your home?" on a first date.
- ✕ "How many people have you slept with?"
- ✕ Anything that compares them to your ex.
- ✕ Questions fired one after another, without sharing back.
- ✕ Anything you would not want asked of you.

If someone asks you something you do not want to answer, you are allowed to say, "I would rather not say yet", and then ask them something else.

WORKSHEET

YOUR CONVERSATION SHEET

MY 30-SECOND STORY

THREE THINGS I CAN TALK ABOUT

MY ONE-LINE ANSWER ABOUT MY PAST

MY PACE SENTENCE

FIVE CARDS I WILL TRY THIS WEEK

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DATING CUSTOMS: WHAT IS NORMAL WHERE YOU LIVE

Customs vary by city, age and background. Surveys on them are small and often company-run, and I found none on first dates for over-35s, so treat this as common practice and be kind.

Who pays	Surveys disagree. In US polls, answers were split between "the man", "whoever asked" and "split it". A UK survey found "split evenly" the most common answer. The safe move in all three countries: offer to split, or say "this one is on me, next one is yours", and accept a no kindly.
What to call it	In the USA and Canada people say "date" fairly early. In the UK, "meeting up" or "going for a drink" is common before anyone says "date". Match the other person's word.
Where to meet	A public place, in daylight, that you chose or know. Tell a friend where you are going and when you will message them. This is general safety advice, not a rule of any one country.
Apps	Pew (USA, 2022) found Tinder, Match and Bumble the most used among online daters. UK figures (Ofcom, 2024) show Tinder, Hinge and Bumble with the largest reach, and that Plenty of Fish and Badoo skew towards ages 35 to 54. No reliable ranking for Canada was found. Pick the app where people your age actually are.

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WHERE TO GET HELP

IF YOU FEEL HOPELESS OR UNSAFE

USA	**988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.** Call or text 988, or chat at 988lifeline.org/chat. Free, 24/7. Emergency: 911.
Canada	**9-8-8 Suicide Crisis Helpline.** Call or text 988, 24/7, in English and French. Info: 988.ca. Emergency: 911.
UK	**Samaritans:** 116 123 (free, 24/7). **Shout:** text SHOUT to 85258. **NHS 111** for urgent mental-health help (choose the mental-health option). Emergency: 999.

IF A PARTNER OR EX FRIGHTENS YOU

USA	**National Domestic Violence Hotline:** 1-800-799-7233, or text START to 88788. thehotline.org. Internet use can be monitored: use a safe device.
Canada	There is no single national line. Find your province at **canada.ca** (search "gender-based violence crisis lines") or look up shelters at **sheltersafe.ca**. Emergency: 911.
UK	**National Domestic Abuse Helpline:** 0808 2000 247 (free, 24/7). **Men's Advice Line:** 0808 801 0327 for men experiencing abuse. If you cannot speak on a 999 call, press 55.

CHECK FIRST

Numbers and hours change. If one fails, search the service's official website.

USA · CANADA · UK

IF YOU THINK YOU ARE BEING SCAMMED

Stop contact. Do not send more money. Tell your bank or card company straight away, keep the messages and screenshots, and report it. Shame keeps scams going: you are not the first, and reporting helps.

USA	Report to the FTC at **reportfraud.ftc.gov** and to the FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center at **ic3.gov**. If you sent money, tell your bank or card company straight away.
Canada	Report to the **Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre: 1-888-495-8501**, or online at antifraudcentre-centreantifraude.ca. If you lost money, also contact your local police and your bank.
UK	Report to **Report Fraud: reportfraud.police.uk, 0300 123 2040** (England, Wales and Northern Ireland; in Scotland call Police Scotland on 101). It replaced Action Fraud in December 2025. To reach your own bank's fraud team, **dial 159**.

CHECK FIRST

Numbers and hours change. If one fails, search the service's official website.

REMEMBER

SMALL STEPS BEAT PERFECT LINES

You do not need to be smooth. You need to be **curious, honest and kind**. Ask one question. Follow up once. Share a little. Go at your pace.

- [ ] I tried one easy card this week.
- [ ] I followed up on an answer.
- [ ] I said one honest line about myself.
- [ ] I said my pace out loud.
- [ ] I stopped when something felt wrong.

Sources used, in short: Huang et al. 2017 (question asking), Boothby et al. 2018 (liking gap), Aron et al. 1997 (closeness), Pew Research Center 2023 (US online daters). All with the limits noted above.

BE CALM.

BE CURIOUS.

BE REAL.

— Dorian Wolfe